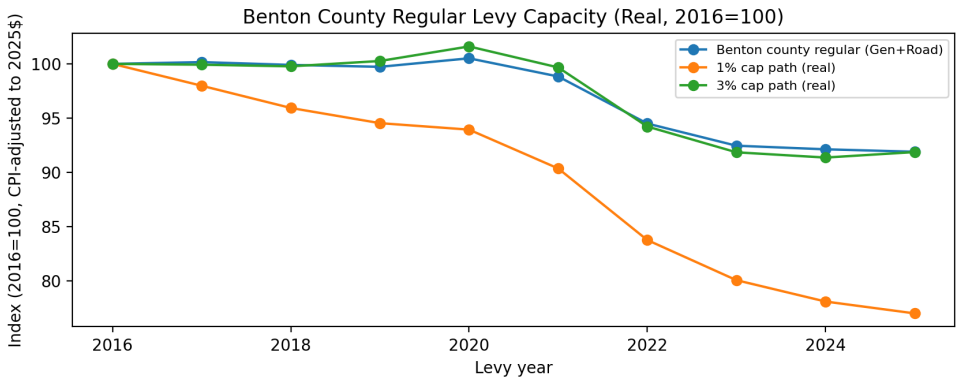
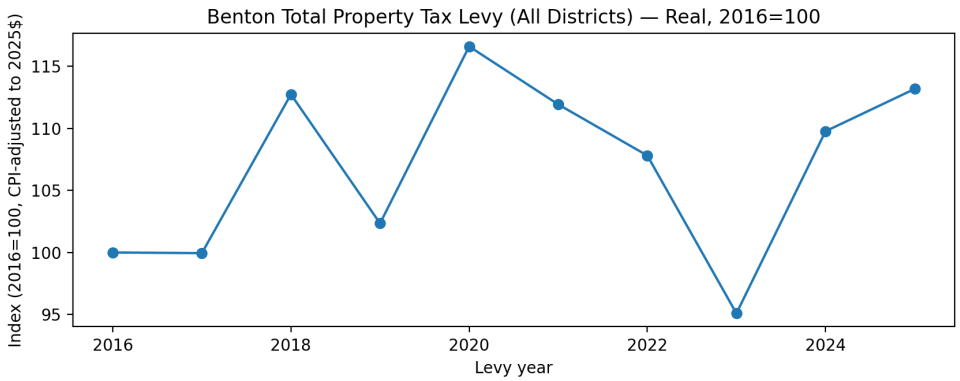
Levy Limit vs Inflation: Statewide Mechanics + Benton Reality + Rural Cor

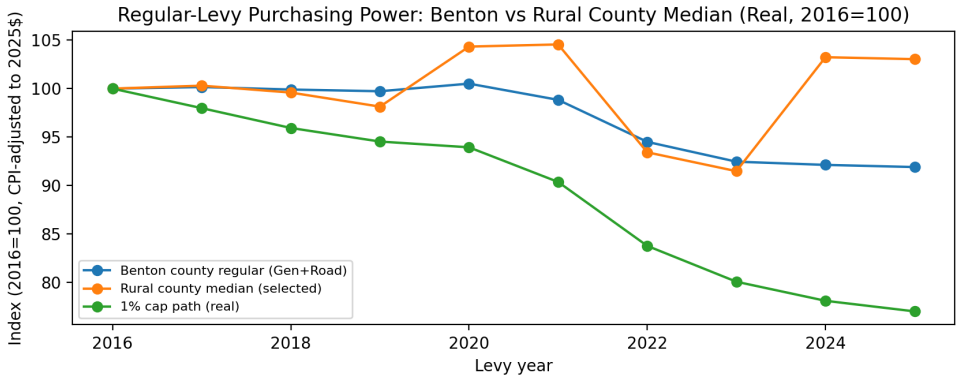
Data: WA DOR “All County Levy Detail” (2010–2025) + CPI-U Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue (BLS/FRED). Indices shown are CPI-adjusted (real)

Key takeaways (real purchasing power):

- Under a 1% levy limit, inflation erodes purchasing power: the “1% cap path” is -23.0% real vs 2016 by 2025 (CPI-adjusted).
- Benton County regular levy (County General + County Road) is -8.1% real vs 2016 by 2025 — consistent with the structural squeeze.
- Benton total levy (all districts) is +13.2% real vs 2016 by 2025 — reflecting voter-approved and state components that can move differently than county regular.
- Selected rural counties’ median regular-levy purchasing power is +3.0% real vs 2016 by 2025, illustrating the disproportionate pressure on small/rural capacity.







Interpretation note: these are budget-capacity mechanics (not a tax-rate story). Total tax bills also depend on assessed values and voter-approved levies.